

Muhammad Usman Naeem

usman.naeem@tufts.edu

usman-naeem.com

Education

Tufts University

Ph.D., Economics & Public Policy

Fields: Development; Environmental; Behavioural; Public

Medford, MA, USA

Expected 2027

Lahore University of Management Sciences

M.S., Economics

Lahore, Pakistan

2015

National University of Singapore

B.A., Economics

Singapore

2009

Research Positions

Harvard University, Department of Economics

Visiting Fellow

Cambridge, MA, USA

Jan–Jun 2026

International Growth Centre

Country Economist

Pakistan

2015–2021

References

Steve Cicala

steve.cicala@tufts.edu

Kyle Emerick

kyle.emerick@tufts.edu

Michael Greenstone

mgreenst@uchicago.edu

Frank Schilbach

fschilb@mit.edu

Job Market Paper

“The Idle Margin: Why Everyday Conservation Goes Undone”

Abstract. Vehicle idling—leaving the engine running while stopped—is a repeated conservation decision in which private and social incentives can point in the same direction: for sufficiently long stops, switching off saves fuel while reducing emissions. Why, then, do drivers persist in idling? In partnership with a telematics firm in Pakistan, I collect 10-second GPS data on ignition status, speed, and location from 6,621 private vehicles. The average vehicle idles for 27 minutes per observed day. Baseline beliefs reveal widespread misperceptions about whether warming up an engine benefits engine life and when shutting off begins to save fuel or reduce environmental harm. I use a randomised additive design that varies private information, social information, payments, and an in-car reminder. Private information reduces daily idling from stops longer than 30 seconds by 1.8 minutes, or 9% of the control mean, with effects persisting after treatment ends. Estimated benefits are 3.7 times programme costs over the eight-week intervention, with about half accruing directly to drivers through fuel savings. Adding social information or payments produces no detectable additional reduction. By contrast, activating a device that provides repeated in-car reminders *increases* idling by 1.0 minute, with the increase concentrated in long idling spells—a pattern consistent with procrastination. The results identify idling as a malleable and consequential behavioural margin, while showing that interventions designed to improve it can backfire.

Working Papers

“Subsidies and Debt under Nonlinear Electricity Pricing”

with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

“Preaching Against Power Theft”

with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

“Hardening the Grid: Technology versus Enforcement”

with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

Selected Work in Progress

“Technology Subsidies and Crop Residue Burning”

with B. Kelsey Jack, Ben Moscona, and Michael Greenstone

“Small Farms, Coordination, and Air Pollution”

with Steve Cicala and Kyle Emerick

“Industrial Pollution and Emissions Disclosure”

with Michael Greenstone

Research Grants

Total funding as PI/Co-PI: over \$1.1 million.

£57,463 (IGC); \$13,972 (Weiss)	The Idle Margin: Why Everyday Conservation Goes Undone
£277,762 (IGC)	Subsidies and Debt under Nonlinear Electricity Pricing
\$167,904 (Weiss; K-CAI); £64,097 (IGC)	Preaching Against Power Theft
£124,677 (IGC); \$24,874 (Weiss)	Hardening the Grid: Technology versus Enforcement
\$109,938 (ATAI; DERF); £24,919 (IGC)	Technology Subsidies and Crop Residue Burning
£31,172 (IGC)	Small Farms, Coordination, and Air Pollution
£66,272 (IGC)	Industrial Pollution and Emissions Disclosure

Presentations (* forthcoming)

2027	Econometric Society CSW Asia Meeting*
2026	Harvard, Cities & Development Conference*; LSE*; LUMS*; IGC–World Bank ieConnect Roundtable*; Harvard, Development Advising Group; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop*
2025	Stanford, Behavioral Public Economics Boot Camp; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop
2024	Berkeley, Environmental & Energy Economics Summer School; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop
2023	MIT, Behavioral Economics; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop

Teaching

Tufts University

Medford, MA, USA

Teaching Assistant, Advanced Empirical Methods for Doctoral Students	2026–2027
Teaching Assistant, Intermediate Macroeconomic Theory (undergraduate)	2025–2026
Teaching Assistant, Behavioral Economics (graduate)	2023–2026